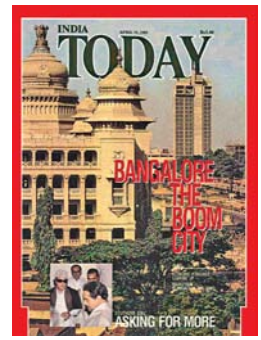
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Bangalored. Coined sometime in the early years of the 21st century, the word used to mark out a unique Indian success. At the height of the outsourcing boom, an American would use the word to convey defeat in a long-distance economic competition. Bangalore, to take the old and familiar anglicised form of the name, was our own Silicon Valley. It was our sunrise city, our El Dorado. The world was its oyster. What possibly could go wrong with this script? Well, trust India to snatch defeat from the jaws of victory. That American word has been turned inside out. Now it just as likely conveys an instrument of self-torture. The city may have renamed itself as Bengaluru in 2005 to suit rising nativist sentiments, but it has been 'Bangalored'—and has no one else but itself to blame for it.

For a country that had mastered urban planning 5,000 years ago with the Harappan cities, we have unlearned whatever we knew. From north to south, east to west, our cities are in a shambolic state. To be sure, this is less a case of being bad at creating but being alarmingly efficient at destroying. You see Mumbai and Chennai routinely go under after the rains. There seems to be a fatalistic acceptance of this, as if it is a part of their lives. Other cities pop up too in the headlines for the assorted kinds of mess they get into, whether it is endless traffic jams, water shortage, garbage disposal, pollution or crumbling infrastructure.



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But of all these, Bengaluru is the one that evokes the maximum pathos. Built at a site on the Deccan Plateau chosen by its 16th century founder Kempe Gowda, its altitude of 3,000 feet from mean sea level still gives it a hill station feel. With great weather, an abundance of parks and lakes and a genteel population, it used to be known as a place to retire to. That was in the days before its economy went on an adrenaline overdose. With a special wistfulness, Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa writes the cover story this week—Bangalore is the city he grew up in. He also wrote INDIA TODAY's first cover story on it in 1983. We had anointed it as the 'Boom City' then. Now, nearly four decades later, he returns to chronicle the layers of gloom hanging over the same city as it threatens to go bust. That three days of torrential rains in early September caused unprecedented flooding came as an unhappy coincidence in the middle of his reporting—stunning scenes of city-wide devastation played out over days as even the IT corridor was inundated. Even some business tycoons had to be rescued on tractors from posh colonies and luxury villas.

But the flooding, and the unseemly sight of a beautiful city going under, was only a metaphor for a much larger malaise of Bengaluru's crumbling infrastructure. It was the symptom and not the disease itself. In Chengappa's estimation, the city's crown jewel—the infotech sector—is unfairly blamed for the present mess. As recorded in his 1983 cover story, the city was already booming in the 1980s. Infosys founding chairman N.R. Narayana Murthy first saw Bangalore in the 1960s on a family visit: leave alone the traffic nightmare of today, even the human population on the roads was scanty. And by the time he shifted Infosys from Pune in the 1980s, he was moving into an already irrevocably changed landscape.

The first wave of the city's growth, in fact, happened in the 1960s when public sector giants like HMT, BEL, ITI and BEML were set up to take advantage of its clean air and its scientific and technological base. Then, in the late Seventies, with the city having surplus power, its planners opened the doors to businesses from across the country. Bombay was then beset with union issues and Calcutta was plagued by the Naxal movement, so industrialists from these original megalopolises of India moved in droves to Bangalore. By 1983, it was already among the fastest growing cities of the world.

The IT boom came on top of that: beginning in the Eighties, picking up steam and global cachet by the Nineties, and pretty much exploding in the 2000s. It became a city, as Chengappa writes, "where start-ups spring up like daisies every morning and grow into unicorns by sundown". The present-day tech corridor, a glittering 17-km arc of glass and stainless-steel skyscrapers on the southeast swathe of the ceaselessly expanding metropolis, houses an estimated 400 of the Fortune 500 list of corporates. It's a dense concentration of wealth generators: some $22 billion per annum, accounting for a third of Bengaluru's revenue and employing close to 1 million people. But it contributed to the story of broken infrastructure: in the past decade alone, the city has grown four-fold in size and now straddles 800 sq. km. Also, its population nearly trebled from 5.7 million in 2001 to 14.2 million last year. It is India's third largest metro now, having overtaken Chennai and Kolkata.

How does one cope with growth on that scale, at that pace? Unfortunately, successive state governments are responsible for being riddled with endemic corruption, sloth and systemic confusion. All this has left the city bereft of a grand design. Its last master plan expired in 2015 and the new one is yet to be cleared. This has conferred on it the air of a city perennially in trouble. Murthy of Infosys suggests that Bengaluru get a mayor, a leader with stature who operates like a CEO, with the multiplicity of civic agencies reporting to him or her, and invested with financial autonomy. The mayor should govern the city with an iron hand, making the elected corporators and civic officials accountable and ensuring timely implementation of infrastructure projects, while cutting down on corruption. At the moment, Bengaluru has eight civic agencies responsible for its upkeep, often working at cross-purposes, or not at all. As India develops economically, urbanisation is inevitable. That's how a country progresses. But if the governance of our cities remains in today's pathetic state, we are heading for many urban nightmares. Bengaluru, with its wealth and high quality of human resources, could set an example that others could emulate.

(Aroon Purie)